3 The Iron Age

Learning Outcomes

The learner:

- identifies the different ages of human history and describes the main features of the life of the people in each age.
- explains when and where human beings learnt how to use iron.
- lists ways in which iron was useful to man.
- illustrates how the discovery of iron changed the lives of people.
- names some major civilizations of the Iron Age.

Let's Take-off

Communication

These are some materials that the earliest human beings used. Put a circle around the ones that we use today.

- stone • wood • bone • horn • copper • bronze • iron

How do we use these today? Talk about this in class. C-1.1

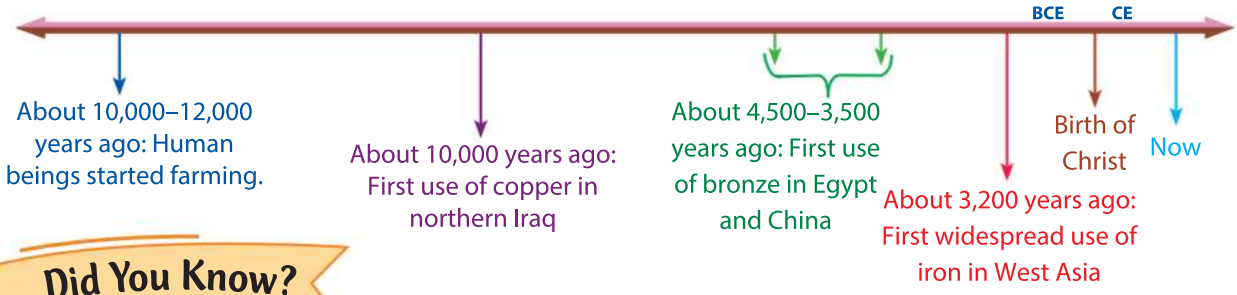
THE 'AGES' OF HUMAN HISTORY

The materials used by early human beings are still useful for us today. As you know, we have learnt about the life of these human beings through the discovery of artefacts used by them. You have also learnt that to make it easier to study early human history, historians have divided it into 'ages'. An **age** is a very long period of time. The table on the next page tell us some important things about the ages. In this chapter you will learn about the life of the people in the Iron Age—a very important stage in human history.

One age did not come to an end neatly before another one started. When people started using bronze, they were still using stone and copper too. Similarly, when people started using iron, they were also still using bronze. The Iron Age was the time when people began to use tools and weapons made of iron. The different ages did not happen at the same time all over the world. In Egypt, people made bronze articles 4,500 years ago, whereas in China this happened a thousand years later.

Age	Materials used	Life of the people
Stone Age	• Stone, wood, bone, and horn • In the later part, people learnt to make pottery using clay.	• Hunting and gathering • Later, farming developed along with animal rearing and trade. • Villages and towns grew.
Copper and Bronze Ages	All the materials used earlier, and also: • Copper • Bronze made by mixing copper with tin	• Various civilizations began to develop. They had good agriculture and the earliest cities. • Cities and civilizations traded amongst themselves to get the goods that they needed.
Iron Age	The materials used earlier, and also: • Iron	

Historians think that the earliest widespread use of iron started about 3,200 years ago, or around **1200 BCE**, in West Asia in the area that is now Türkiye. For a long time, only the people here knew how to use iron, but this knowledge gradually spread to other parts of the world. The timeline here shows you some important events in human history.



Did You Know?

Early iron artefacts—beads and a dagger—have been found in Egypt. Analysis has shown that they were made from iron found in **meteorites** that fell on to the earth from space. Ancient Egyptians called this iron, **ba-en-pet**, which means 'Stone or Metal from Heaven'.

USEFULNESS OF IRON

Iron was an extremely useful metal for human beings. You will understand this if you look at the differences between bronze and iron.

BRONZE	IRON
Not a very hard metal	Much harder than bronze, so, better for making tools and weapons.
Made with copper and tin. Tin was available in only a few places.	Found in many parts of the world.
Melts at a lower temperature. People melted it and poured it into moulds to make tools or weapons.	Melts at a much higher temperature. It was heated and the red-hot iron was beaten to make tools or weapons. This process made strong tools and weapons.

Discuss

Communication

Why were stronger and harder tools better for early human beings? C-6.1

Melted bronze being poured into a mould

Red-hot iron being beaten into a tool

Several iron artefacts have been found. These show that people had learnt to make useful objects, particularly tools and weapons, from this metal. Some artefacts that have been found are axes, ploughshares (used to dig fields), sickles (used to harvest crops), nails, swords, spears, arrowheads and pots.

Iron axe (left) and arrowhead (right)—The axe would have been fitted with a wooden handle and the arrowhead with a wooden shaft.

THE CHANGES OF THE IRON AGE

Agriculture

Iron axes were used to clear forests so that more land was available for farming. Iron ploughshares, fixed to wooden ploughs, could dig deeper and turn the soil better. Better crops could grow, so more food was produced. Iron sickles were stronger so they were better for **harvesting** ripe crops.

Buildings and Crafts

Artefacts like iron cooking pots and nails show that craft improved as did building activities. Some artefacts that have been found are iron cooking pots and nails.

Trade

As tools improved, more food and other goods were produced than were actually needed. This is called a **surplus**. Towns and villages sold their surplus to each other. Trade between different regions increased. With increasing trade, money began to be used. Some early coins were of iron, but later coins were of metals like silver and gold. Coins were also made of a mixture of silver and gold.

Early coins of iron, copper, silver and gold

Cities and Urban Centres

With improved agriculture, everyone did not need to be a farmer. Many people were now free to do other things. For example: there were blacksmiths who worked with iron. Some people became writers. Cities and **urban** centres (areas connected to cities) grew. Some were very grand, with magnificent buildings, art, craft and literature. They became the centres for trade as well.

Knowledge of India

The best steel in the Roman civilization was Seric steel from southern India. Trade in this metal was part of Indian trade with Rome.

Weapons and Warfare

Iron made better weapons like swords, spears and arrowheads. Wooden wheels on war chariots were fitted with iron **spokes** and **rims**. These chariots were faster. People with such chariots and iron weapons won battles easily against those who did not know about iron or its uses. This helped people to gain more territory over which they could rule. Kingdoms became bigger.

Different types of arrowheads

HOTS

Critical Thinking

The Hittites in West Asia were the first to use iron extensively, but they tried to prevent other people from learning about it. Why do you think they did this?

C-6.1

CIVILIZATIONS OF THE IRON AGE

With the growth of cities and urban centres, **civilizations** developed. 'Civilization' means that a place is highly developed in areas like art, trade, writing and architecture.

Two civilizations of the Iron Age were the Greek and the Roman civilizations. The maps on this page show you their locations. Find the Mediterranean Sea in both the maps.

Ancient Greece had several independent city states. You can see some marked in the map. In the Roman Empire, Rome was the chief city of the empire, though it had several other cities too.

Ancient Greece at the time of the Greek civilization

Think and Answer

Map reading | Critical Thinking

Look at the maps and talk about these questions:

- Which two aspects of life today are linked to locations in ancient Greece? (Hint: sports)
- The Romans referred to the Mediterranean Sea as 'Mare Nostrum' meaning 'our sea'. Why do you think that they did so?

C-5.3

The huge Roman Empire in 117 CE

The discovery and use of iron was an extremely important development in human history. Iron is still extensively used today.

A Better World

Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)

Goal 9: Industry, Innovation and Infrastructure

Early human beings were constantly making advances in their technology. They learnt that by mixing tin with copper, they could make bronze. Later, they learnt how to use iron to make tools and weapons. Did these innovations result in more good or more harm?

C-6.1

Values and Life Skills

- Think of all the things that you use or see around you. Identify (with the help of your teacher) the ones that are made of iron.
- Discuss the importance of the discovery of iron in our lives. This will help you to understand how the past is with us even today.

REMEMBER

The Iron Age

- Early human history is divided into long periods of time called 'Ages' based on the materials that people used.
- The various Ages happened at different times in different places.
- The Iron Age is the period when people began to use iron to make tools and weapons.
- Iron is a hard metal and so it was used to make strong weapons and tools.
- The use of iron changed human lives in many ways.
- Two Iron Age civilizations were the Greek and Roman civilizations.

NEW WORDS

Meteorite	a piece of rock from outer space that hits the earth's surface
Surplus	an amount that is extra or more than you need
Urban	connected with a town or city
Spoke	a thin straight piece of metal that connects the centre of a wheel to its outer edge, for example on a bicycle wheel
Rim	the edge of something in the shape of a circle, for example, the rim of a cycle tyre
Civilization	a state of human society that is very developed and organized

EXERCISES

Remembering and Understanding

A. Choose the correct answers.

1. Historians think that the earliest widespread use of iron started about 3,200 years ago/5,000 years ago/2,000 years ago.
2. Bronze articles were made at the same time by Egypt and China/earlier in Egypt than in China/earlier in China.
3. Bronze/Iron/Copper is better for making tools and weapons because it is a harder metal.
4. How to use iron was known only to some people for a long time/ was soon learnt by other people/was an important development.

5. Read the statements below and choose the correct option.

   Statement (A): In the Iron Age cities and urban centres grew.

   Statement (B): They had grand buildings.

   (a) Both A and B are true, and B is the correct explanation of A.

   (b) Both A and B are true, but B is not the correct explanation of A.

   (c) A is true but B is false.

   (d) A is false but B is true.

B. Fill in the blanks.

1. The ..... of human history lasted for thousands of years.
2. When people started using iron, they continued to use .....
3. With improved agriculture, people could produce more ..... than was required.
4. ..... means that a place is highly developed in areas like art, trade, writing, etc.
5. Two Iron Age civilizations are the ..... and ..... civilizations.

C. Match the following.

A	B
1. Meteorite	(a) Connected with a town or city
2. Surplus Goods	(b) Piece of rock from space that hits the earth's surface
3. Iron Spokes and Rims	(c) Mixture of copper and tin
4. Bronze	(d) Trade increased
5. Urban	(e) Made war chariots faster

D. Write true or false. Correct the false statements in your book.

1. The artefacts used by early people tell us about them and their lives.
2. When one Age ended, another one started.
3. Iron is more widely found than tin.
4. During the Iron Age, many people had time to do things other than farming.
5. Trading centres were located far away from the cities.

E. Answer the following questions.

1. What is the Iron Age?
2. When and where did the Iron Age first appear?
3. Explain how each of these iron tools helped to improve agriculture: axes, ploughshares, sickles.
4. How was iron made into tools and weapons?
5. What were the effects of better weapons made of iron?

DO AND LEARN

A. Picture Study

Look at this picture and answer the questions.

1. What is this? 2. Which time does this belong to?

C-6.1 Observation

B. On Your Own

1. **Metals of the metal age**
   Bring objects made of copper, bronze and iron to class. You can also look at silver and gold objects. Talk about their differences that you notice.

   C-1.1

2. Many words that we use in English have their roots in Latin, the language of the ancient Romans. Find out the Latin roots of these words: dental, audience, central, annual. Share this information in class.

   Communication SI Languages

TP

C. In a Group

Work in small groups to put together a PowerPoint or chart presentation on:

1. The sources from the Stone and Iron ages
2. How these sources show the change in people's lives

SI Computer Science

D. Pair and Share:

Along with your partner in class, discuss how the Iron Age is different from the time today.

C-6.1 Communication

Weblinks For more information, go to:

- **The Age of Metals—Five Things You Should Know:** https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4QMlLsRS7vY (Accessed on 31 July 2025)
- **The Iron Age for Kids/History Made Easy:** https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Omtc-rHexnw (Accessed on 31 July 2025)

What I Learnt

Self-review

Colour the smileys to show how well you have understood the concepts.	Completely	Mostly	Need help
• I can identify the different ages of human history and describe the main features of the life of the people in each age.	☺	☺	☺
• I can explain when and where human beings learnt how to use iron.	☺	☺	☺
• I can list ways in which iron was useful to human beings.	☺	☺	☺
• I can illustrate how the discovery of iron changed the lives of people.	☺	☺	☺
• I can name some major civilizations of the Iron Age.	☺	☺	☺